



Palace of the Shirvanshahs

The luxurious residence built for the shahs of Shirvan on top of a hill in the ancient walled city of Baku

In the 15th century, Shah Khalilullah of Shirvan moved his capital to the port of Baku, on the Caspian Sea in present-day Azerbaijan, where he had a palace complex built. Within its walls, the complex occupies three levels. The main palace is at the summit of the hill, set in a courtyard, which forms the uppermost level; this level also contains the mausoleum of a court scholar, Seyid Yahya Bakuvi. To the side of the palace garden is an octagonal building enclosed by arcades, the *Divankhana*. On the second, lower level, the Shah's mosque and royal burial vaults occupy another courtyard; the lowest level consists of a terrace containing sunken bath-houses.

Constructed in the first half of the 15th century, with a grand eastern portal known as Murad's Gate added to the wall in 1585, the Palace of the Shirvanshahs is the focal point of the Icheri Sheher, the Inner City of Baku. It is described in its UNESCO World Heritage Site citation as "one of the pearls of Azerbaijan's architecture."

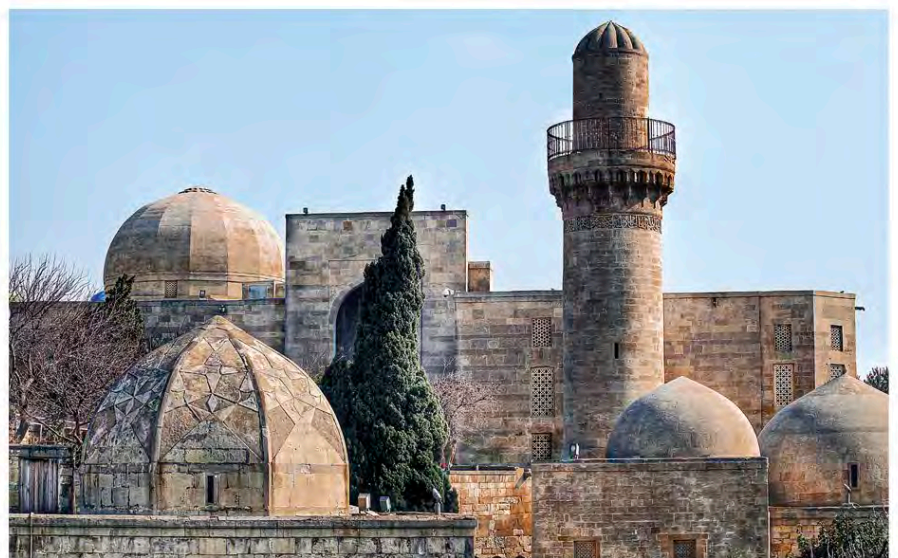
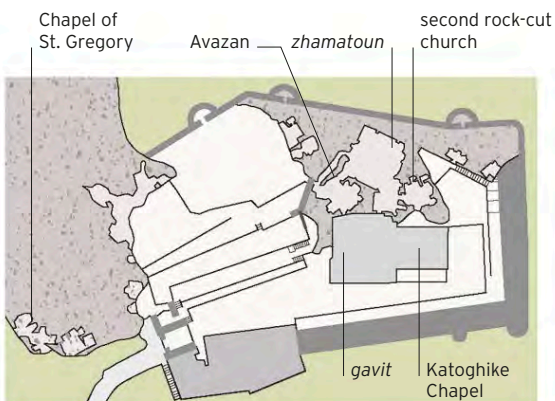


△ CARVED INSCRIPTIONS

Many of the buildings of the palace complex are decorated with stone friezes carved with historical and religious inscriptions in relief.

THE MONASTERY COMPLEX

Apart from the Chapel of St. Gregory the Illuminator, outside the walls of the complex, the principal churches of Geghard are all accessed via the *gavit*. The main Katoghike Chapel is free-standing but abuts the cliffside; the *gavit* cuts into the mountain, leading to the Avazan (meaning "basin"), the two *zhamatoun* containing tombs, and a second rock-cut church.



△ PALACE IN THE EVENING SUN

The domed rooftop of the palace is visible behind the hexagonal dome of the royal mausoleum and the domes and minaret of the palace mosque. All of these structures are made of blocks of the same honey-colored stone.